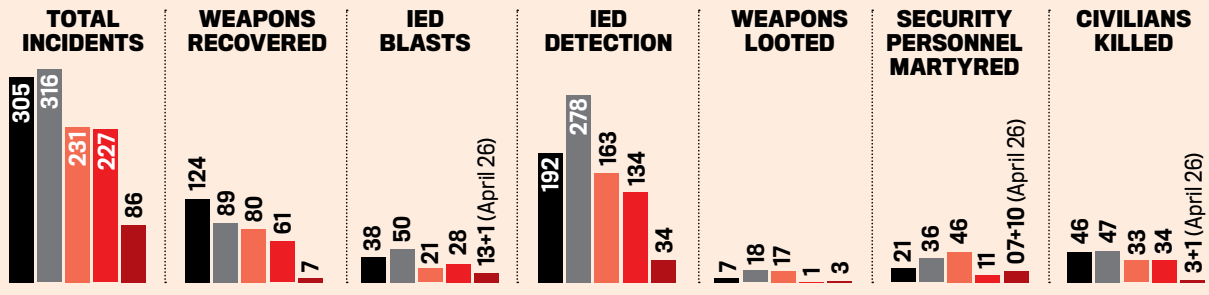


ANI

SUPREME SACRIFICE
Chhattisgarh CM Bhupesh Baghel and others carry the coffin of a security personnel killed in the IED blast

MAOIST ACTIVITY IN BASTAR IN RECENT YEARS



was injured. They were being taken back by security forces to Dantewada for arrest formalities and treatment in a pick-up truck, which was leading the three-vehicle convoy, when an IED exploded, completely destroying the vehicle in the middle and killing all 11 people on board. There were numerous road blocks set up en route by locals, mostly children, to demand donations for aama pandum, a tribal agriculture festival. The road blocks slowed down the convoy and their role in the tragic incident cannot be ruled out.

The details of the incident are key to understanding how complacency on the part of those who plan security movements can have bloody outcomes. For one, security experts feel that the convoy should not have moved back during daytime. "Force extraction is done at night as that considerably reduces the risk of vehicles being caught in IED blasts, as visibility is lower. Also, motor bikes are to be preferred over vehicles that carry more personnel, so casualties can be minimised in case of an explosion," says a senior police officer formerly in charge of anti-Maoist operations. Secondly, the police claim that demining of the road was done but the way an IED—perhaps planted deep under the surface—escaped detection speaks of some basic inadequacy in surveilling methods. Preliminary investigation suggests preparations for the IED was made two months ago. The wire attached to the explosive was laid two-three inches below the ground and grass had grown on it. The wire trailed into the forest by the road for around 150 metres. The Maoists seemed to have used 'foxholes'—tunnels dug from the side of the road to right below the black top—which is packed with earth and left for later use. As the time for an attack draws near, explosives are placed under the road using the foxhole. In the past, surrendered Maoist cadres have told the police about tunnels, the detection of which helped save many lives.

DRG MEN HAVE GREAT TERRAIN KNOWLEDGE, BUT OFTEN DON'T FOLLOW PROCEDURES, SAY SENIOR OFFICERS

Five of the 10 security personnel killed were surrendered Maoists who had joined the DRG. While DRG personnel, mostly from a tribal background, have great knowledge of the terrain and have proven to be formidable fighters in face-offs with Maoists, most senior officers acknowledge that the force does have a discipline issue. It is reflected in the reluctance to follow procedures and drills, which can have deadly consequences. DRG personnel therefore need to be closely monitored throughout an operation, for which presence of senior